SALES TRAINING DEBRIEF

Pitch High, Show the Stack, Let the Customer Choose

Session led by Corie Dawson, Director

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The thesis in one line

Stop pitching down out of fear. Show three priced options, pitch high, and let the customer reveal what they can afford by what they choose — not by what they say.

> *"They either have the money or they don't. You can't control that. The danger is when they DO have the money and you talk yourself out of the sale."* — Corie

1. Core mindset shifts

Mindset 1: Buyers either have the money or they don't

You cannot tell from the outside which side a prospect is on. So stop guessing. Stop deciding for them what they can afford. Run the same pitch every time and let the process unfold.

If they don't have the money, you lose nothing. The danger is the prospect who DOES have the money and you under-pitch — you leave thousands on the table because past lost deals shrunk your confidence.

> *"It is none of your business what they can afford. You are not their financial manager."* — Corie

Mindset 2: Pitch high — every time

Buyers always negotiate down. Nobody walks back a price upward. So your starting number sets the ceiling.

Rule of thumb from the session:

- Start at $11k — they push you to $10k.
- Start at $10k — they push you to $9k.
- Start at $3k — they push you to $2k.

Pitching medium gets you low. Pitching high gets you medium. Stop self-selecting the small package because you're scared of pushback.

Mindset 3: Buyers are liars (not maliciously)

When a customer says "my budget is $15k," they are telling you the truth based on what they've seen so far. Your job is to give them more information — show them what better looks like — so they can update their own anchor.

> *"Buyers are liars — not because they're lying, but because they're telling you the truth with the information they have. Give them more information to bridge the gap between risk and reward."* — Corie

Mindset 4: Manage what they DO, not what they SAY

Words are signals. Actions are confirmation. The customer who steps back into the car for a second test drive is signalling capacity to buy, regardless of what their mouth is doing. The customer who needs "a week" to think is signalling something else entirely (covered later).

2. The pitch framework — show, don't just tell

The single biggest behaviour change Corie wants from the team: stop quoting prices in a vacuum. Always pair price with a visible product, side-by-side at multiple tiers.

The three-website demo

When pitching a website rebuild, show the prospect three live examples we've built — at three price points:

1. A $7,000 site — solid, clean, baseline.
2. An $8,000 site — same baseline plus a couple of extras.
3. A $10,000 site — extra landing pages, more polish.

Then ask: "Which one do you like the look of best?" Not "what's your budget?" — that question is, in Corie's words, offensive and lazy. The prospect picks a tier visually, and that pick reveals their real price tolerance without you ever having to ask for it.

> *"Which website do you like the look of? — that's the same question as which price point can you afford. But it's reframed so the customer answers honestly without feeling poor."* — Corie

Why this works

The customer can't actually tell the websites apart on quality — to them they're all "fine websites." What they're really doing is telling you which price feels safe. You've used their own visual preference to do the qualifying for you.

Always lead with proof

Before talking price, show the prospect what we've done. For SEO that means live keyword rankings:

- Pull up a client's ranked keywords. Have them type each into Google live.

- Show the result. "This client paid $1,500/month. They have 12 keywords on page one."
- Pair it with three written testimonials.

Monkey see, monkey do. Stop selling SEO on theory.

3. The "embedded conversation" — indirect-direct selling

A long part of the session was a roleplay of selling a BMW M3 to a buyer who walked in with a "$15k budget." The point of the roleplay isn't car sales — it's a transferable closing technique Corie calls embedded decision-making.

The principle

Don't ask buyers direct questions about price, intent, or readiness. They lie when asked directly. Instead, build a sequence where the buyer answers those questions through their behaviour.

> *"I ask indirect-direct questions to get the direct answer I want — by what they do, not what they say."* — Corie

How it played out

4. Don't ask "what's your budget?" Ask what kind of car they like. Bring them to a high-end option (M3, $40k) plus a mid option ($28k Audi) plus the cheap option ($15k Golf). Their brain swells to fit the higher anchor.
5. Hand them the keys. Send them on a test drive. Coming back to the car is the signal they want it — they wouldn't bother if they didn't have capacity.
6. When they hesitate, ask: "Where do I need to be on price for you to make a decision today?" Their answer is a real number, not a fantasy.
7. Go to the manager (real or theatrical), come back with a number close — but not equal — to what they asked. The friction is the close.

The same logic in our world

Substitute "show the three websites" for the test drive. Substitute "let me speak to my manager" for the price negotiation step. The choreography is identical.

4. Handling "I need to think about it"

This is the line that is costing the team the most deals. Corie was emphatic about how to read it.

The diagnostic

"I need to think about it" almost always means one of three things:

- **Price.** They like the product but the number isn't landing. This is the most common case and it is recoverable.

- **Trust.** You said something dumb in the pitch and they're backing away. This is usually not recoverable in the same call — move on.
- **Spousal / partner approval.** Genuine — and easy to handle.

The script when they ask for time

Before letting them go, ask one more question — softly, with the tonality of curious-and-caring:

> *"Can I ask you a personal question? Was the holdback price, or was it the product?"*

If they say price, follow with: "Where do I need to be?" Get a real number. Then either:

- Get close to the number ("I couldn't do $800 but I got you to $825") and ask if they want to move forward today.
- If they still need time, professionally hand them the rope: "You asked for one day — I'll give you four. I'll call Monday at 11."

The 825-not-800 detail matters. Round numbers signal "I had more room." Odd numbers signal "this is the squeeze." That tonality of slight regret — "I'm sorry I couldn't quite get there" — does the work.

When "I need a week" is real

If a prospect with money asks for a full week, the silent translation is: "I don't trust you yet." There's no recovering that in the call. Don't plead. Don't pursue. Tell them you won't chase them and to call back when ready. Their reaction tells you whether the deal was real.

> *"The most offensive thing on earth is when a salesperson makes it clear that you are valuable to them. Pull back, and watch what they do."* — Corie (paraphrased)

"I need to talk to my husband/wife"

Treat this as a buying signal, not an objection. Reassure, give them four days when they ask for one, and book the follow-up call. About 80% close on the next contact.

5. The trial close

After the prospect has picked their preferred website tier and the price is agreed, do not wait for them to volunteer a yes. Use a trial close:

> *"Are you comfortable going to the next step?"*

If they say "what's the next step?" — they're buying time and they know it. Push gently:

> *"We've done the hard part. You're comfortable with the website and the price. I don't see a reason for us not to do business together. All I need is a $500 deposit to get you on the schedule. Sound fair?"*

Add light scarcity that is real, not invented: "We're booking up — I want to lock in your build slot." Don't lie about the calendar. Do mention it.

6. Pricing psychology — the high-price safety signal

The Charlotte Tilbury vs $12.50 foundation example is the cleanest illustration of the principle:

When you pitch low	When you pitch high
$12.50 foundation: "What's in it? What will it do to my skin? Why is it so cheap?"	$370 collagen at Mecca: "It's expensive but it must be quality. The Kardashians use it."
Cheap = unsafe = suspicious.	Expensive = safe = aspirational.
Customer interrogates ingredients.	Customer interrogates their own budget — not the product.

High price reads as quality and safety. When you walk in with a $3,000 website quote you are positioning us as a low-quality provider before the prospect has seen anything. Lead with the $10k example. Let them work their way down.

> *"It's never been about what the website looks like. They all look the same to the customer. What's changing is the price tag attached. So which one they pick tells you what they can spend, without you ever having to ask."* — Corie

The Apple parallel

Apple builds a $3,800 phone not because anyone needs 1TB of storage, but because the existence of the $3,800 model makes the $2,200 model feel reasonable. Three priced website options do the same job.

7. Tonality — what your voice should be doing

Corie returned several times to the tone the salesperson uses on key lines. Words alone don't close — delivery does.

Stop saying / sounding like	Start saying / sounding like
"What's your budget?"	"What sort of car / website do you like the look of?"
"It's a big decision."	"It's a small investment relative to what it returns."
Apologetic, hedging, hopeful.	Curious. Caring. Slightly disappointed for them when squeezing the price.
Pushy / desperate when pursuing.	Professional follow-up: "It's my job to follow you up — that's what I get paid to do."

Write down the phrase: "Where do we need to be on the price point?" Practice it until the tonality is curious and caring, never pleading.

8. Behaviours to change — this week

Specific corrections Corie called out in the session, translated into action:

8. **Stop self-pricing the deal down.** If you're quoting $4,700 because you're scared, lift it to $7,200. Pitch high every time, default position.
9. **Build a three-tier visual deck before every pitch.** Three live websites, three SEO case studies, three testimonials. No pitch goes out without them.
10. **Replace "what's your budget" with "which one do you like the look of best?"** Make the swap mandatory in the first call.
11. **Always ask "where do we need to be?" before letting a hesitant prospect off the call.** Do not drop the price unilaterally. Get a number from them, then go negotiate it.
12. **When they ask for one day, give them four — and book the call back.** Frame it as professionalism, not pressure.
13. **Treat "I need a week" as a trust failure, not a price objection.** Don't chase. Move to the next prospect and review what was said in the pitch.
14. **Stop assuming the prospect's wallet.** Run the same high pitch every time. Let the customer reveal their level.

Final reminder. We have a strong, distinctive product. The reason deals aren't closing isn't the product — it's the framing of the price and the choreography of the close. Both are fixable, and both start on the next call.